LONG **LIVES** THE **BLUES**

SOULMATE, SHILLONG'S ICONIC BLUES-ROCK ACT, WILL SOON TURN 20, BUT THIS ISN'T MAKING THEM COMPLACENT



Over the past 19 years, **SOULMATE** has been instumental in reviving interest in the blues in India

Locked down in Shillong for much of the past three years, Rudy Wallang and Tipriti Kharbangar—better known as blues-rock trailblazers Soulmate—had live-streaming as the only option to connect with their fans and promote their latest album *Give Love*, released in August 2020. Even the handful of occasions they got to travel last year, like a small live-streamed gig in Guwahati, were tense affairs, tainted a little by pandemic paranoia. Which is probably why Rudy Wallang sounds so happy when we talk about the five-city tour the band has just concluded. "It's a good feeling to be able to play in front of live audiences again, to see people actually listening to us, and then meeting them afterwards," says Wallang over the phone from Shillong. "Wherever we played, you could feel the electricity in the room. There was so much anticipation and joy on people's faces."

Back when Soulmate first started performing in 2003, only a handful of groups were playing blues music in India, all of whom performed to a dwindling audience of older fans. But over the past 19 years, aided by an assortment of accomplished session musicians, Soulmate has been instrumental in reviving interest in the blues. They have picked up a legion of adoring fans and toured the world.

"It has been a wonderful journey, filled with adventure and love from fans," says Wallang. "At our gigs these days, we have a wide spectrum of people coming, from 16 to 17-year-old kids to 60 to 70-year-olds. That really feels good."

Most bands about to hit the 20th-year mark would be making big anniversary preparations, but Soulmate are too busy with their plans for 2022 to think that far ahead. The duo has a big event coming up in Shillong for International Blues Music Day, and they are in the mixing and mastering process for their next album, which they hope will be out before Christmas.

"It will be a surprise," says Wallang, a little mischievously. "It's a little bit different from what we usually do. But we made this with The Clansmen [a Khasi-folk group who regularly collaborate with Soulmate], so that should probably give you a hint." ■

–Bhanuj Kappal

THE HILLS ARE ALIVE...

...WITH THE SOUNDS OF MUSIC THESE ARTISTS ARE MAKING

LO! PENINSULA

This Imphal shoegaze/ dreampop trio embody the DIY dream, creating moody, distortion-drenched soundscapes reflecting a sense of alienation. Psychedelia filtered through new-wave's ironic dourness. Their debut album *AKA Lo! Peninsula* comes highly recommended.





TABA CHAKE

Born in a small village in Arunachal Pradesh, this Mumbai-based guitarist and singer-songwriter blends twee, finger-plucked acoustic guitar with indie-pop melodies and tribal folk storytelling influences. He's also a polyglot, performing with ease across five languages—English, Hindi, Nepali, Assamese and Nyishi.



VIRIE

Kohima-native Virie has been making waves with moody, dreamy pop songs that showcase her ethereal voice. Singles like 'Aliya' and 'Feel Good' hint at an artist who's just about to reach her creative peak.